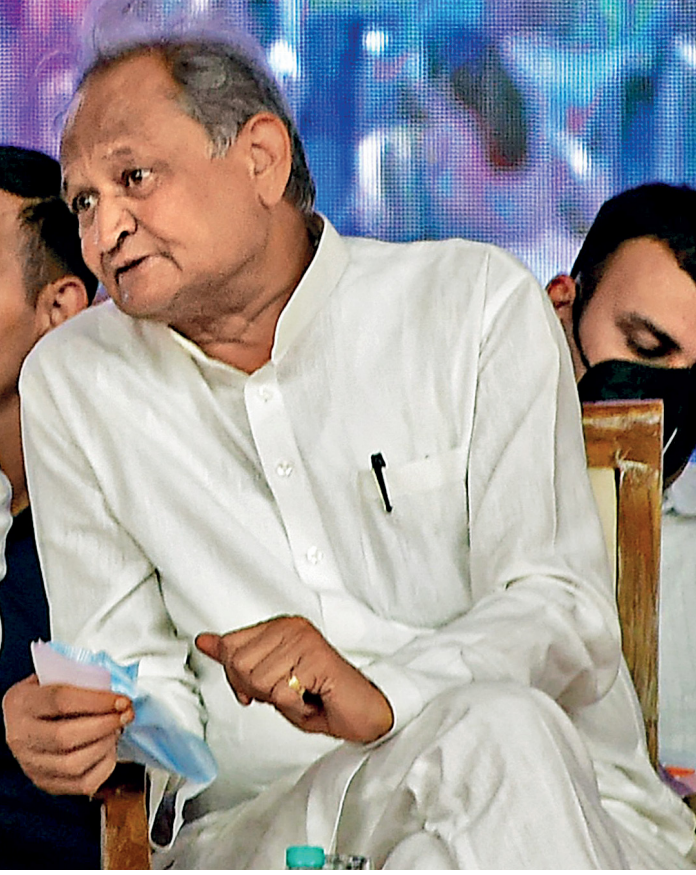


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home, had been booked in advance by Rathore. Then, identical printed resignation letters were already ready at Dhariwal's home. Can such planning happen without the CM's consent?" asks a CWC member. Gehlot's side asserts that all the arrangements were made on September 25 itself, when it became clear that the high command would remove him and instal Pilot. The tents and chairs at Dhariwal's house apparently came about two hours after the MLAs had started coming in.

However, it is clear that Gehlot had been planning for this eventuality for some time now—or at least since his name started doing the rounds as Congress presidential candidate. He had been regularly meeting MLAs and addressing their demands and grievances ever since Pilot's failed coup. Back then, he would often jokingly tell the MLAs: "You will get tired of asking me, but I will not get tired giving." When it was time for them to return the favour, they obliged—hoodwinking the two observers and forcing them to return to Delhi empty-handed. But while it may have helped Gehlot save his chair for the time being, he has lost the high command's trust forever.

Having bitten more than he could chew, it was unlikely that the Gandhis would take kindly to his attempts to outsmart them and challenge their authority in the bargain, especially as they had believed him to be a trusted Congress loyalist. A disciplined soldier from his NSUI (National Students' Union of India) days, Gehlot was picked by Indira Gandhi to contest his first election in 1977. He had been the organising force behind her rally in Jodhpur after Emergency was lifted. In 1984, he was Rajiv Gandhi's poll agent in the Amethi constituency. He remained loyal to the family even when P.V. Narasimha Rao and Sitaram Kesri were at the helm of the Congress.

Which is why Congress observers were caught by absolute surprise when their trusted lieutenant turned "rebel". As a senior leader from Rajasthan told INDIA TODAY after his revolt, "I never had a very good equation with Gehlot. But I can certainly say that none can be more loyal to the Gandhis than he has been." Gehlot's aides insisted their leader's non-compliance was with Sonia's messenger Maken, and not with the Congress president herself. But few were willing to buy the argument.

In raising the banner of revolt, Gehlot managed to expose how poorly advised the high command was, failing to gauge his strength and capacity for manipulation. Sending the two observers sans any homework betrayed their lack of connect with ground reality and the expectation that everyone would fall in line without a murmur. Never before was the absence of a strong political sounding board for the Gandhis felt more acutely. "In the past, Ahmed Patel was the connect between the Gandhis and the rest," says a former Union minister. "He could handle the regional satraps, who shared an equation with him. After his death, there is nobody with his kind of stature to manage the backroom manoeuvring." This breakdown of regular communication channels has left a gap between traditional loyalists and the Gandhis, creating fissures in multiple states. It might take Gehlot's open revolt for reality to dawn upon the Congress high command. You could have dismissed Ghulam Nabi Azad as a has-been, but not Ashok Gehlot by any means. Though he may have withdrawn from the race, tendered an apology for not being able to get the resolution passed, he also managed to make a point, and a forceful one at that.

WHY DID GEHLOT REBEL?

Gehlot had never wanted to be Congress president in the first place. Several senior leaders say that he saw no merit in occupying a post that would give him no real authority as long as the three Gandhis were around. This is the first time in Congress history that three members of the Gandhi family are active in politics and a non-Gandhi will be the president. With no precedent to fall back on and no clarity over the functional autonomy Sonia Gandhi's successor from outside the family would have, most Congress veterans, including former Madhya Pradesh chief minister Kamal Nath, had steered clear of the presidential contest. In fact, soon after Gehlot's rebellion, when Sonia Gandhi asked Kamal Nath to step in, he politely refused, saying he wanted to focus on winning back MP next year. Also, unlike the others, Gehlot would have the most to lose, having to give up the chief ministership, even if only a year remains of it and he may not win the next election at all.

Loyalty had not the only thing going for Gehlot. A career politician who had risen through the ranks, he has spent five decades in the Congress. He is, therefore, perfectly attuned to the intricacies and power structure of the Congress. He has served in multiple organisational roles—president of the party's student wing NSUI, president of Rajasthan Congress, party general secretary in-charge of several states, and gen-